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CODING.CARE:
GUIDEBOOKS FOR INTERSECTIONAL AI

by

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Abstract

Critical AI researchers understand the urgent need to understand and rethink how AI systems are defined, developed, regulated, and mitigated. *Coding.Care: Guidebooks for Intersectional AI* argues that integrating critical approaches into AI systems requires building inviting, inclusive spaces. It requires space for more people to engage creatively and critically with each other, and to engage creatively and critically with machine learning as a malleable material and practice. This project demonstrates craft-based, process-oriented approaches to AI that can help meet this challenge.

The dissertation presents guides for fostering critical-creative coding communities as spaces of radical belonging—activated by an ethos and a politics modeled by queer and trans* communities that embrace radical difference. This creates a basis for deep interdisciplinary thought, interrogation of formative principles, and an openness to co-creation and alternative forms necessary to reimagine AI.

With these approaches, it becomes possible to reengage emergent technologies as craftable materials, rather than unassailable forces, and to respond with impactful, sustainable, intersectional interventions. Artists, activists, scholars, and technologists can recast their relationships to emerging technologies by reframing them as crafts like crochet—deflating AI hype, lowering barriers to learning, and emphasizing sustainability and process. Thinking craft-as-technology honors the inherited knowledge of many outsider communities. Thinking technology-as-craft provides a framework to implement those theories, ethics, and tactics as intersectional critical AI.

Coding.Care collects five publications that enact the strategies it theorizes. These works address and unite a wide range of communities by relying upon different voices, forms, formats, and media. They address various stages and processes involved, including machine learning datasets, intersectional AI, coding communities, and embodied algorithmic art:

*Crafting Queer Trans*formative Systems: A Theory in Process* grounds the works that follow in the handscale, process-based approaches, the queer and trans* embodied ethos, and intersectional tactics I use for working toward AI systems as crafted, in-process materials. *Coding.Care: Field Notes for Making Friends with Code* gives courage to pick up unfamiliar tools, find resources to kick off a new programming project, pose questions critically, or solve problems creatively. Its pocket guide discusses how to build a cooperative, interdisciplinary community for co-learning coding like the one I have facilitated since 2019. The *Intersectional AI Toolkit's* co-authored zines are accessible guides to both AI and intersectionality, bringing together artists, activists, academics, makers, technologists, and anyone who wants to understand the automated systems that impact them. The work argues that established but marginalized tactics are necessary for reimagining more critical and equitable machine learning. A *Critical Field Guide for Working with Machine Learning Datasets* translates critical AI theories and data science concepts into practical tips for dataset stewardship. Along with the *Inclusive Datasets Research Guide*, it combines technical skillbuilding and critical thinking for scholars and practitioners beginning to work with large datasets. Lastly, a collection of lyric essays imagine dialogues with five 20th century artists, using the artists' analog practices as pre-responses to the contemporary digital concerns raised by living in an algorithmic age and across this collection.

Together, the guides in *Coding.Care* want to meet readers where they are—as non-academics or those bridging into new fields, looking for a common vocabulary to engage conscientiously with the urgent concerns of AI systems. *Coding.Care* offers an expansive invitation to deepen interdisciplinary

conversation, apply intersectional approaches, and rework AI systems from critical–creative–caring perspectives.

Introduction

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References